

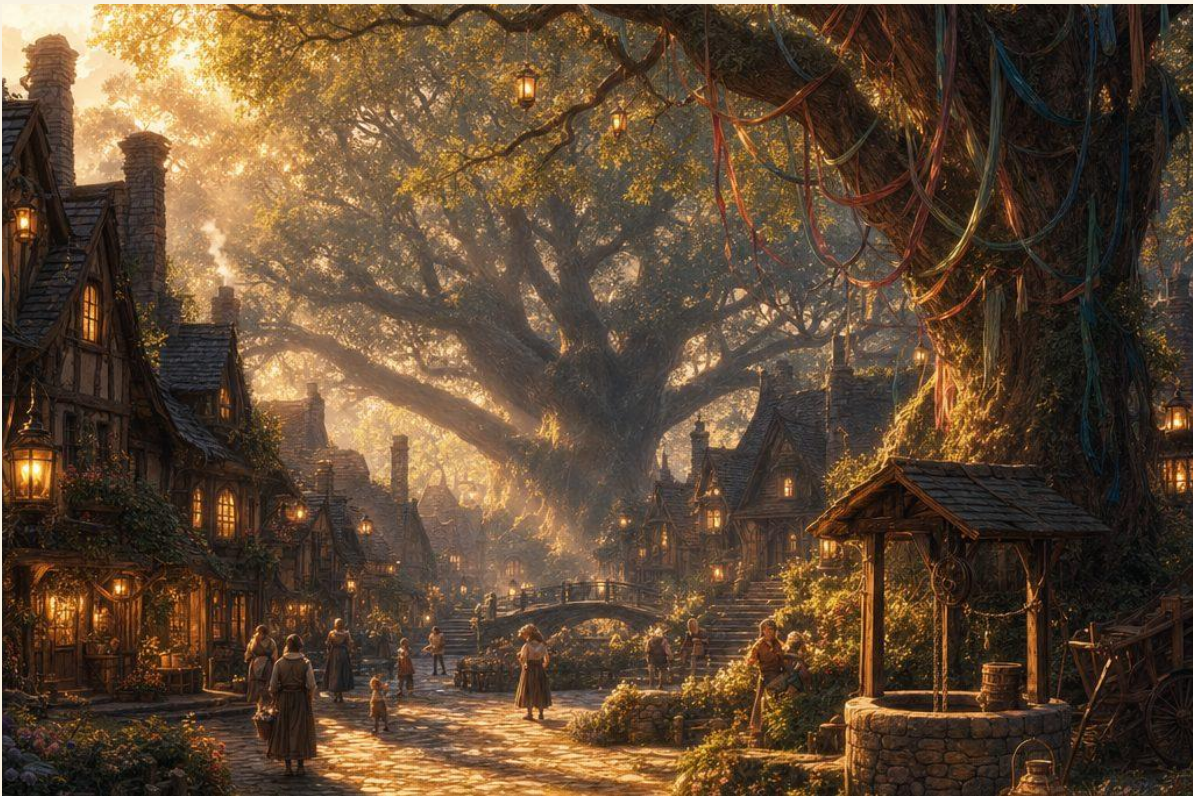


THE GUARDIANS OF ELARIA

SESSION 2

The Road to Ravenstone

An illustrated adventure. Read the gold boxes aloud; the purple boxes are for the DM.



Dawn breaks over Oakshade Village, and the mist lets go at last.

Previously, on The Guardians of Elaria...

Three young heroes collided at the **Gilded Acorn Tavern** in Eldridge Village: **Lilly Glimmergear**, a deep gnome artificer carrying the humming **Essence Sphere** and the sleeping spark of a creature called Pikachu; **Ursa Catchum**, the star reading son of the vanished druid Ash Catchum; and **Stabby Sharpblade**, a goblin monk with sharp teeth and a sharper grin. One friendly tavern brawl later, they were a party.

In the **Forest of Whispers** they befriended **Lickgloom**, a gentle fey creature with a heroic tongue, bested the leek wielding guardian **Duckleaf** and the patient water guardian

Cognifin, and scattered the fog cloaked **Mist Stalkers** on the road. Every strange creature left behind a glowing **mote**: a little piece of another plane, loose in the world. At **Oakshade Village**, Elder Merwin asked the party to find the young herb gatherers lost in the forest, for fifty gold and the village's gratitude. The heroes slept in warm beds above the Old Oak Tavern. And then, morning.

Part One: Morning in Oakshade

Dawn breaks soft and silver over Oakshade Village. A last ribbon of mist clings to the square, curling around the great ribbon hung oak and the old well beside it. The village is waking: shutters open, chimneys breathe, and folk go about their morning with wary glances at the treeline, as they have every morning since the forest began to whisper.

Down the tavern stairs come four travelers, one of them licking the banister. Behind the bar, **Alwen** watches them descend with an approving gleam; word of their deeds in Eldridge arrived ahead of them, the way word always does.

Alwen, setting down plates of warm bread and fresh berries: “Mornin', young ones! Word is already spreading about the lot of you. Folk around here could use a touch of bravery, I will say that much.” She leans in, lowering her voice. “Say, you would not be interested in the professor, by any chance? Rumor is you came looking for strange creatures. The professor has got his fair share, and then some. **Professor Aelwyn** is the name. A peculiar one, that fellow: studies critters and strange energies, trying to understand what has been going on with the forest. He keeps a place called **Ravenstone Laboratory** out in the wilds, but not many are brave enough to go looking.”

The Lost Come Home

Before the last berry is eaten, a shout rings across the square. Then another, and another, and suddenly half the village is running. Through the thinning mist come three young figures with leaves in their hair and empty herb baskets on their arms, blinking at the morning light like children waking from a long nap. The lost herb gatherers have come home: footsore, muddled, and completely unharmed.

Their story spills out in pieces while mothers cry and neighbors cheer. The forest fog had turned them around, and around, and around; every path bent back on itself, and something in the whiteness kept howling, so they hid. Then last night, all at once, the howling stopped and the fog simply... let go. The paths ran straight again, and they walked out by starlight.

Elder Merwin works it through aloud, one smith's thought at a time. “Last night, you say. The very night these four put down those mist beasts on the road.” He turns to the party, and his weathered face folds into a rare smile. “That fog was no weather. It died with



the creatures that wore it. Oakshade owes you more than coin, but coin is what I promised.” And in front of the whole square he counts fifty gold pieces into their hands, proud as if he were knighting them.

► Quest closed: the missing herb gatherers came home dazed but unharmed; the misdirecting fog lifted when the **Mist Stalkers** died. Merwin pays the promised **50 gp**.

Whispers in the Square

With the morning suddenly festive, tongues loosen, and the party spends an hour listening. By the central well, **Nina the herbalist**, elderly and warm, with weathered hands that never stop sorting leaves, waves them over to her stall.

Nina: “It is that forest, see? The air feels different. Heavy. Like it is breathing. I have seen the professor come by in the dead of night, arms full of odd things: stones, jars of glowing water, plants that do not grow here. Says he is studying it. I say it is not for mortal minds to meddle in such things. Lately he goes further out, beyond where the trees are thickest. I only hope he knows what he is dealing with.”

Near the forge, Merwin adds his own measured warning. “Aelwyn is brilliant, no doubt. I would also say he is a tad reckless. Always pushing the boundaries of what is safe to know. If you find him, ask him how far he is willing to go. Tell him to remember what is at stake here. We cannot afford for Oakshade to become a ground for planar... experimentation.”

And at the village edge, a knot of children playing tag stops mid game. A bright eyed girl darts over. “You are looking for the professor, are you not? We see things at night. Creatures. Glowing lights. Some of them talk, even though there is nobody there.” Another child pipes up: “One of them looked like a giant fox, all made of sparks! And another like a... like a big fluffy cloud!” The children trade uneasy looks and scatter back to their game.

Tamsin's Map

As the party compares rumors by the well, a half elf woman with a heavy satchel and a determined look crosses the square to meet them. “You are asking after the professor,” she says, scanning the rooftops as if the words might carry. “My name is **Tamsin**. I work with him. Sort of.”

Tamsin: “Professor Aelwyn studies what is happening out here, things most people would not dare go near. He believes the planar boundaries, the thin walls between our world and others, are shifting. Letting things through. He has been collecting samples, researching the... anomalies. Lately it has become an obsession.” She unrolls the party's map on the well stones and marks a spot in the western wilds: **Ravenstone Laboratory**. “Follow the western path and watch for the fork. When you start feeling like the trees are watching you, you are almost there.” Her grim smile fades. “The professor says the creatures are harmless. But I have seen how some of them act. Like they are protecting something. Whatever is happening, it will not stop here.”

The party shoulders their packs in the bright morning square. Alwen waves from her doorway: “Good luck to you! And watch out for the strange ones out there!” Lickgloom flicks its tongue at a butterfly, misses, and trots after its friends, and Oakshade watches its newest heroes walk west into the trees.

Part Two: The Western Road

Fifty gold richer and one mystery deeper, the party followed Tamsin's map into the wilds, where the road itself seemed to grow stranger with every mile.

The Mudskip Ambush

Half a mile out, the forest thickens and the path turns soggy underfoot. Little streams wander across the trail, the air hangs humid and close, and somewhere nearby water bubbles where no stream should be. The trees open on a clearing pocked with shallow pools of murky brown water.

One of the larger pools ripples. Not the way wind ripples water: the other way. Then three creatures burst from the mud in a fan of brown spray, part salamander, part fish, slick and blue green, with fin feet, wagging tails, and wide grins full of tiny needle teeth. Their eyes gleam with mischief and a flicker of light that does not belong to this world. **Mudskips:** creatures of the Plane of Water, slipped through the thinning walls, and absolutely delighted to see travelers.

► Three **Mudskips** (CR 1/2 each). The mud is difficult terrain for everyone but them; they dart in, splash, and dive back into the pools. Resistant to fire, vulnerable to lightning: the fire tricks Lilly and Ursa lean on need rethinking today.

The fight is half battle, half mud wrestling. The Mudskips spit gobs of muck, slap with their tails, and skate across the wet ground while the heroes' boots sink and stick. Stabby goes down face first exactly once and comes up spitting mud and declaring war. But Lilly's sparks find the water, Ursa's magic pins the pools, and one by one the giggling ambushers are beaten, until the last Mudskip collapses into a plain brown puddle with an almost apologetic *blorp*.

Where each creature fell, a small **mote of water energy** rises, pulsing with faint blue light, hovering just long enough to be seen before it thins into the air. The pattern from the Forest of Whispers holds: the strange creatures are not invaders. They are leaks. Lilly bottles a few samples of the shimmering elemental mud; the professor, she suspects, will want to see this.

► Intelligence (Arcana) or Wisdom (Nature) DC 13: the motes are fragments of elemental energy from the **Plane of Water**, more proof the boundaries are weakening. Loot: **Elemental Mud Samples** for Professor Aelwyn.



The Grimfang War Band

Beyond the marsh the path narrows, dense brush pressing close on either side: the kind of road that makes a traveler's neck prickle. The birdsong stops. A branch cracks. And then the brush is full of eyes.

Goblins melt out of the shadows on every side, rough faced and hostile, weapons ready. With them come worse things: a snarling **worg** straining to pounce, a thick shouldered **orc** with a club like a fence post, and a **hobgoblin** settling a crossbow on a branch further back. At their center stands a stocky **goblin boss** with a scar across his face, and when his eyes find Stabby, he grins like a trap snapping shut. These are the **Grimfang**, a rival clan with an old grudge against Stabby's people.

Grimfang boss: “Well, well. If it is not one of the **Bloodfang Clan**, wandering far from home! You are bold, bringing friends. Shame they will make such a tasty meal!”

► The **Grimfang war band**: 2 goblin archers on the flanks, a worg and an orc in the melee, a hobgoblin sniping from the rear, and a goblin boss barking orders. The boss taunts Stabby about the Bloodfang all through the fight. Beaten, the survivors flee.

The ambush is coordinated, vicious, and very unlucky in its choice of victims. Arrows hiss from both flanks; Stabby plucks one out of the air an inch from Lilly's hat and twirls it like a prize. The worg lunges and meets Ursa's magic head on. The orc swings his great club in whistling arcs while the boss dances behind him, shouting insults about the Bloodfang Clan, about weakness, about the little monk who left. Stabby's grin never moves. His feet do. Between the monk's flashing strikes, the artificer's crackling bolts, and the druid's starlight, the war band's courage leaks out of it like sand from a torn sack.

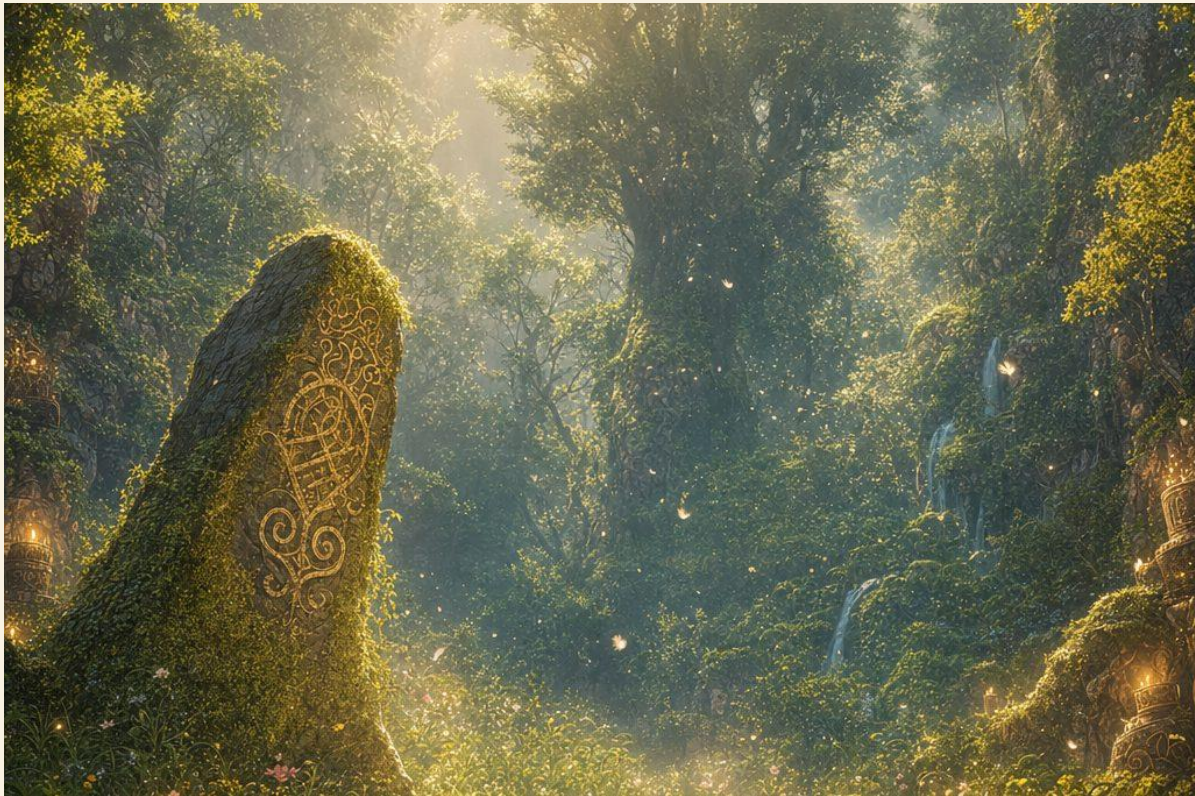
The boss is last, back pedaling, still snarling. “This is not over, Bloodfang!” he spits, and then the Grimfang are gone into the brush, dragging their pride behind them. The party stands a long moment in the quiet. Stabby picks up the arrow he caught and tucks it in his sash, and says nothing at all about home.



Part Three: The Whispering Glade

Bruised, muddy, and victorious twice over, the party pressed on as the sun sank low, and the road repaid them with wonder.

Toward sunset the path opens into a serene clearing the Oakshade folk call the **Whispering Glade**. Ancient trees ring it round, their leaves rustling softly in air that holds no wind at all, so that the whole glade seems to murmur. At its center stands an old stone monument, cloaked in moss, carved with runes that glow faint as embers.



The Whispering Glade murmurs in windless air around its rune carved monument.

A calm settles over the party the moment they step inside. Time feels slower here; the forest's sounds arrive muffled, as if from another room. Then, one by one, strange things begin to hum. The **Essence Sphere** in Lilly's arms wakes with a soft glow and a note like a struck glass. The three **enchanted potatoes** in Ursa's pack grow warm as fresh bread. And along Ursa's arm, his Dragonmark tingles, the way it does when something living and frightened is near. But nothing here is frightened. Something here is *waiting*.

Ursa feels the pull before he understands it: a quiet insistence, drawing his hand toward the monument. When his palm touches the mossy stone, the runes flare to life, gentle light washing across the glade. The Sphere answers in Lilly's arms. The potatoes pulse, all three in unison, like little buried heartbeats. And the world folds softly away.

The Vision of Elaria

The glade is gone. The party stands together in a vast, ethereal expanse of swirling mist and drifting lights, and out of the luminescence a figure gathers: a radiant being woven of intertwining vines, starlight, and flowing water, vast and gentle at once, her eyes holding the depth of the night sky. This is **Elaria**, and though none of them has ever heard her name, all of them somehow know it.



Elaria, guardian of the planes, gathers out of starlight and vine above the three heroes.

Elaria: “Seekers of truth. You have touched the threads that bind the realms. I am Elaria, guardian of the planes and of the balance that sustains them. A great disturbance ripples through existence, and the boundaries between worlds grow thin.”

Her gaze turns to Ursa, and it is warm as summer. “Child of Ash. Your father delved into mysteries few dare to explore. The enchanted potatoes you carry are remnants of a shattered covenant, a safeguard against the unraveling. They hold the key to restoring what was lost.”

To Lilly: “Ingenious artificer. The Essence Sphere you bear, once a mere power core, now resonates with energies beyond its making. It can channel and stabilize the motes of wayward creatures caught between planes.”

And to Stabby, with something almost like a smile in the starlight: “Wanderer of shadows. Your path is interwoven with chaos and choice. Your actions may sway the tides toward harmony, or deepen the discord.”

Around them the mists flash with visions: landscapes cracking like ice, elemental fire and flood, creatures of every plane tumbling through gaps in the world. **Elaria:** “The disturbances are but a symptom of a greater malady. An ancient entity seeks to exploit this weakness, consuming the essence of worlds. Unite your strengths. Restore the safeguards. Mend the fractures, before all is lost.”

The expanse dissolves like breath off a mirror, and the party is standing in the Whispering Glade again, hands and hearts still tingling. Night has fallen while no time passed at all, and the stars overhead burn with extraordinary brilliance, as if someone up there knows they are being watched. On the monument, the runes dim slowly to a patient glow.

Ursa, quietly: “My father was trying to protect the balance of the planes. These potatoes are more than heirlooms. We have to finish what he started.”

Lilly, turning the Sphere over in her hands: “The power core was never just a gift. If it can stabilize these planar energies, we might save more than Pikachu.”

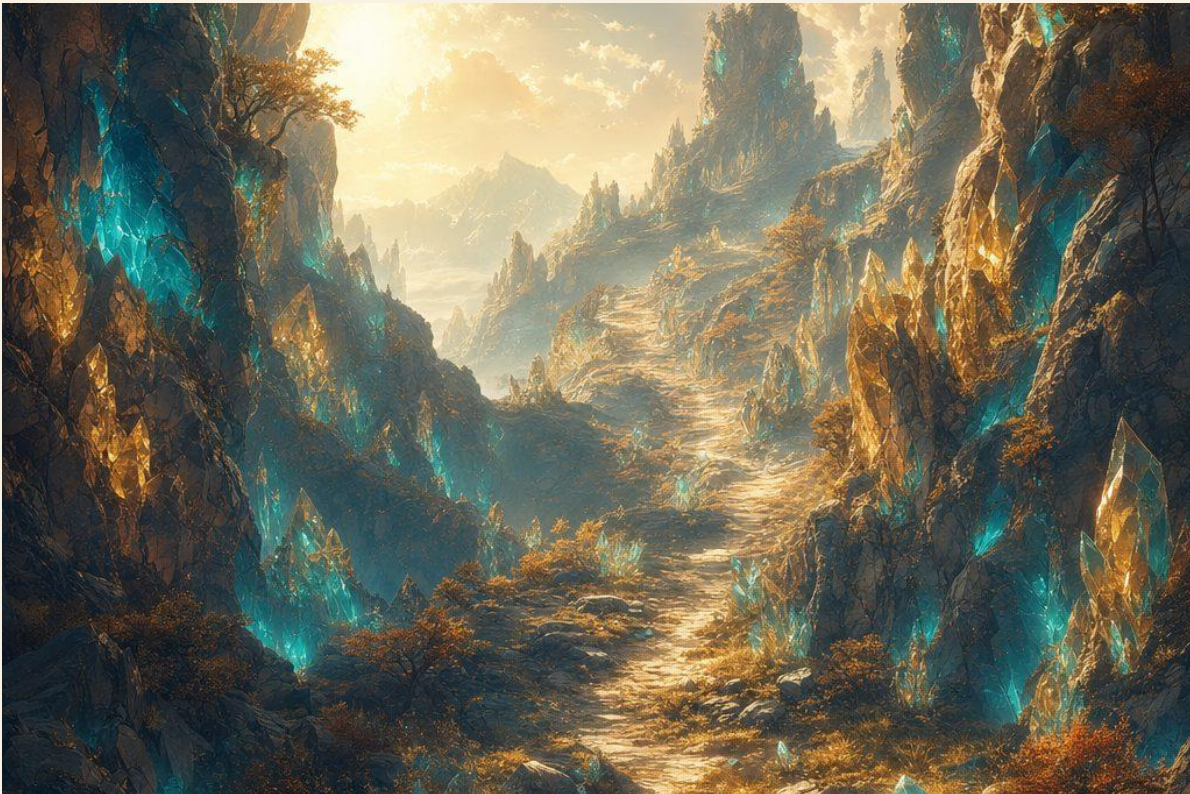
Stabby, grinning at the stars: “So causing a bit of chaos might actually help this time. Good. I am very qualified.”

► **Boons of the vision.** Ursa gains **Planar Awareness** for 24 hours (sense planar anomalies within 1 mile). The Essence Sphere gains **Planar Attunement** (advantage on Arcana checks concerning planar magic and creatures, permanent). Stabby gains **Glimpse of Possibility** (advantage on his next saving throw or ability check). The glade is safe ground: the party took a short rest here.

Part Four: The Stone Serpent

Rested and lit from within by what they had seen, the party climbed on toward Ravenstone by starlight, and the mountain itself rose to meet them.

The last stretch to Ravenstone climbs through rugged country, the path narrowing between steep cliffs with loose stones rolling underfoot. The party is picking their way single file when the ground begins to shake. Pebbles dance. Cracks race along the trail. And with a deep, resonant rumble, the path ahead heaves upward and becomes a creature.



The last stretch to Ravenstone climbs between crystal studded cliffs.

Terranox rises: a great serpent of living stone and packed earth, rocky scales glinting in the fading light, eyes glowing from within like windows onto slow magma. It regards the party the way a mountain regards weather, and then it strikes. There is no talking to it, no bargaining, no clever password. Some guardians test. This one only defends.



Terranox, the stone serpent of the Plane of Earth, rises from the mountain path.

► **Terranox**, CR 4 elemental of the **Plane of Earth**. No parley. Immune to fire, so flame tricks fail again; it stomps the ground to knock heroes flat and coils around spellcasters. Loose rocks fall throughout: DC 12 Dexterity save or 1d10 bludgeoning.

It is the hardest fight of their young lives. Terranox's tail sweeps like a falling tree; its stone coils catch Ursa mid spell and squeeze until Stabby's flurry of blows cracks the grip loose. Fire splashes off the creature like rain off a roof, so Lilly rewires her cannon on her knees in the dark while Ursa calls down starlight instead of flame. Chip by chip, crack by crack, the heroes carve the mountain down, until at last the great serpent shudders, sighs a long gravel sigh, and collapses into a heap of inert stone and settling dust.

In the rubble where its heart was, the party finds an **Earth Mote**: a small crystalline fragment pulsing with elemental energy, heavy with the raw strength of the Plane of Earth. This one does not drift away. Lilly wraps it carefully with the mud samples and a few glittering **stone fragments** of the serpent's hide. The professor is going to have questions. So do they.

Part Five: Ravenstone Laboratory

Dusty, weary, and carrying pieces of three planes in their packs, the party crested the last wooded hill as twilight fell.

Below them, nestled in a tranquil valley of ancient oaks and shimmering ponds, stands **Ravenstone Laboratory**: a graceful structure of stone and glass, its turrets spiraling upward like reaching fingers, capped with metal domes that catch the last orange and purple of the sky. Warm light glows from every window. The path down is lined with luminescent flowers that sway gently in the still air, and among the trees flit small, impossible creatures: some with wings like leaves, some like tiny mammals traced in glowing lines.



Lilly points the way as Ravenstone Laboratory glitters awake in the dusk below.

The creatures are not shy. A little fox with a leaf shaped tail pads right up to Lilly, sniffs her boot with great scholarly interest, and darts back into the foliage.

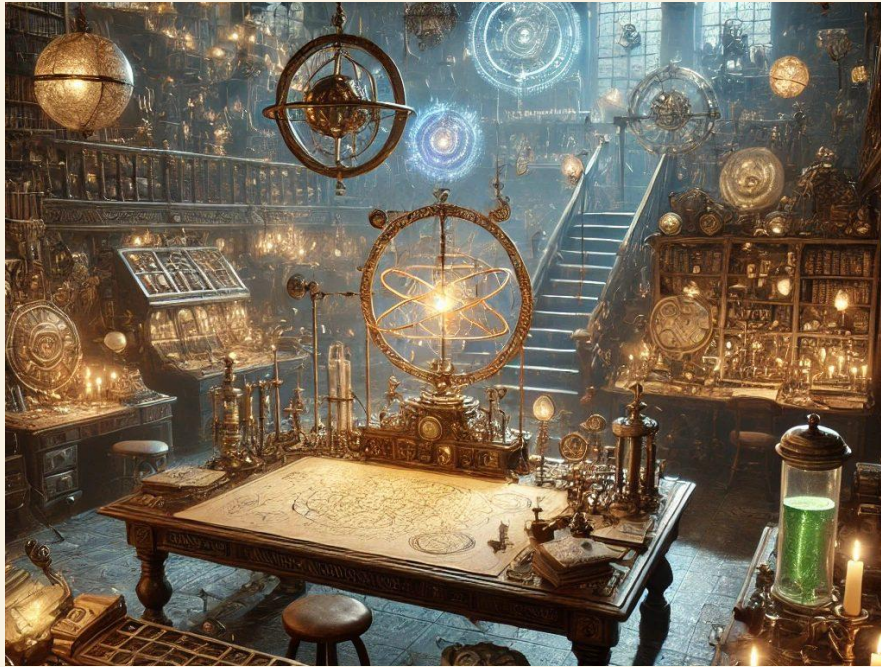
Lilly, eyes sparkling: “Did you see that? I have never encountered wildlife like this before!”

Ursa: “There is something special about this place. The veil between worlds feels thinner here.”

Stabby: “Or maybe the critters just know a friendly face when they see one.”

The grand wooden doors swing open on their own as the party approaches, breathing out the scent of old books, fresh parchment, and a crackle of ozone. Inside, wooden beams arch beneath ceilings painted with stars and mythical beasts; shelves of books and artifacts climb the walls between tall windows. And everywhere, creatures. A rabbit with fur like blooming flowers dozes on a windowsill. A bird with feathers that flicker like small flames preens on a perch. A turtle drifts past at ankle height, its shell swirling with what looks like captive

seawater. A tiny dragon whelp with shimmering scales flutters up to the party, studies them with keen eyes, chirps a melodious greeting, and zips away up a spiral staircase, clearly expecting to be followed.



The great hall of Ravenstone Laboratory, where every shelf has a tenant.

Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone

The staircase winds around an atrium of hanging plants and softly glowing crystals, opening into a vast study where bookshelves rise to a domed ceiling painted as the night sky. At a great wooden desk buried in open tomes, scrolls, and peculiar brass instruments stands the master of the house: a **tall high elf** with long silver hair, sharp emerald eyes, and robes that split the difference between a scholar's gown and a field jacket. He looks up, and his whole face lights with delight.

Aelwyn: “Ah, visitors! How wonderful. I do not get many these days.”

Introductions are made all around: Lilly Glimmergear, Ursa Catchum, Stabby Sharpblade. “Please, call me Aelwyn,” the professor says, spreading his hands to the creatures perched on cushions and chandeliers around the study. “Any friend of these marvelous creatures is a friend of mine.” Then his gaze falls on the fourth traveler, currently tasting a bookshelf, and his emerald eyes go wide. “My word. Is that a **Lickgloom** you have there? I have only read of them in the ancient texts. Remarkable!”



Stabby: “You would not believe the day we have had. Mud creatures, rock serpents, a goddess made of stars, and now this place. It is like stepping into a storybook.”

Aelwyn, chuckling: “I can imagine. The world is full of wonders, especially now, with the boundaries between realms becoming... flexible.” He waves them into deep chairs by the hearth, and a small bipedal salamander with a cheerful flame flickering on its tail trots over with a tray of steaming herbal tea, entirely unbothered by its own job title. “Not originally from here, most of my companions,” Aelwyn says, sipping. “They have appeared over the past few years, from adjacent planes intersecting with ours. I have devoted my research to understanding the shifts in our world’s fabric. It sounds as though you four have been doing field work on my behalf.”

The party talks late into the evening: the motes, the guardians of the forest, the Grimfang, the vision in the glade. Aelwyn listens the way a dry garden drinks rain. And more than once, the party notices his sharp eyes drifting to the **Essence Sphere** in Lilly’s lap, where it hums its soft, sleeping note.

Guest Quarters

At last Aelwyn notices the road weariness under their excitement and rises. “Forgive me. You must be exhausted. I insist you stay the night; there is much I would like to discuss, and none of it improves after midnight.” A small owl like creature with luminous eyes swoops down at his soft clap and leads the party through corridors hung with tapestries of distant realms, to adjoining rooms with plush beds, moonlit garden windows, and floating crystal lamps that brighten at a touch.

Stabby flops onto his bed with a contented sigh. “Now this is more like it. Beats the hard ground any day.” Lilly touches a crystal lamp and watches it glow, already reverse engineering it in her head. Ursa stands at the window, looking up at stars that seem to look back.

Lickgloom curls at the foot of a bed and is asleep in seconds, tongue out.

At the door, the professor pauses, candle in hand, his gaze resting one more moment on the Essence Sphere glowing gently on Lilly’s nightstand. “Rest well, my young friends,” he says. “Tomorrow, we begin.”



Their second day together held a quest completed, two ambushes weathered, a goddess’s charge laid upon them, a mountain taught respect, and a warm bed in a house full of impossible creatures. Whatever the professor saw when he looked at the Sphere, morning would tell.

Next: Session 3, in which the professor examines the Essence Sphere, three small creatures wait in three baskets, and a dark figure watches from the top of Stormwatch Cliffs.

Appendix: Creatures of Session Two

Compact statistics for the table. The full bestiary, with lore and pictures, lives in the compendium.

Mudskip

Small elemental (Plane of Water), neutral. **CR 1/2**. AC 13 (natural armor), HP 22 (4d6 + 8), Speed 20 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR 12, DEX 14, CON 14, INT 6, WIS 12, CHA 8. Skills Stealth +4, Perception +3.

Resistances fire. Vulnerabilities lightning. Darkvision 60 ft. Understands Aquan.

Amphibious / Mud Dweller. Breathes air and water; ignores muddy difficult terrain.

Mud Spit. +4, range 30 ft., 1d6 + 2 bludgeoning; DC 12 Dexterity save or speed reduced 10 ft.

Tail Slap. +4, reach 5 ft., 1d8 + 2 bludgeoning.

Mud Splash (Recharge 5-6). 15 ft. cone, DC 12 Dexterity save; 2d6 + 2 bludgeoning and blinded one turn on a failure, half damage on a success.

The Grimfang War Band

Rival goblin clan raiders: **2 goblins** with shortbows, **1 worg**, **1 orc**, **1 hobgoblin** with a crossbow, and **1 goblin boss** (scarred; taunts the Bloodfang).

Standard 2024 Monster Manual statistics for each creature.

Tactics. The boss coordinates: archers on the flanks pick at the back line, the worg and orc press the melee, the hobgoblin snipes from cover.

Outcome. Beaten soundly; the survivors fled into the brush. The Grimfang remember.

Terranox

Large elemental (Plane of Earth), unaligned. **CR 4**. AC 16 (natural armor), HP 95 (10d10 + 40), Speed 30 ft., burrow 30 ft.

STR 20, DEX 10, CON 18, INT 5, WIS 11, CHA 6. Darkvision 60 ft., tremorsense 60 ft.

Immunities fire, poison; exhaustion, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone. Resistances nonmagical bludgeoning, piercing, slashing (non adamantine).

Earth Glide / Immutable Form / Elemental Resilience. Burrows through unworked stone without a trace; immune to form altering effects; advantage on saves against magic.

Bite. +7, reach 10 ft., 2d10 + 5 piercing.

Tail Slam. +7, reach 15 ft., 2d8 + 5 bludgeoning; DC 15 Strength save or prone.

Stone Coil (Recharge 5-6). DC 15 Dexterity save or grappled and restrained (escape DC 15), 1d8 + 5 bludgeoning at the start of each of its turns.

Earthquake Stomp (Recharge 6). 20 ft. radius, DC 15 Dexterity save; 4d6 bludgeoning and prone on a failure, half damage on a success.